

“Who?” I asked while I tried to figure it out on my own.

“You.”

“Me?” I asked, feeling confused.

“You’re the only one I can think of that can fill his chair.”

“But I already have a seat at the top tier table,” I objected. “Who will fill my seat?” To make me even more confused, Finlay chuckled. It sounded genuine so I sat up and looked at him. He smiled at me.

“You are usually brilliant, so I forget what an idiot you can be,” he told me and ruffled my hair. I didn’t even try to avoid his hand as I was trying to figure out what I was missing. “The seat you have is made up. It was created for you as we wanted to give you a seat at the table. When you move to the Beta chair, your chair will be removed, because no one else can fill it,” he told me.

“Oh.” Yeah I should have remembered he had created the advisory role for me. I was just so used to it by now. “If I take the Beta chair we will always be one person short. I don’t have a mate so that chair will remain empty,” I told him.

“You don’t know that. Things can happen,” he said. I gave him a smile.

“It will remain empty,” I told him. He shrugged.

“So be it. Look, the pack loves you, they trust and look up to you. I trust you. I don’t have it in me to find a replacement for Martin who isn’t you.”

“Okay. Count me in. If this is what you and the pack needs, I will do it. I will do my best and I’m counting on you to tell me if I’m messing up.” Finlay let out a deep sigh and put his arm around me again, pulling me with him as he leaned back on the couch.

“It will be fine, Red. You are the daughter of a Beta, it’s in your blood.”

“So our pack will have a second born Alpha, and a second born Beta. It has a nice symmetry,” I told him as I relaxed against him. We sat and watched the sun come up.

“Time to get some food, Red. It will be a long day,” Finlay told me. He got up and pulled me with him. For a moment we stood almost toe to toe, looking at each other. For a second I thought this was it, this was our moment. Then we both woke up and took a half step back.

“Come on, Finn, time to show the pack we still got our shit together,” I told him, gave him a smile and headed towards the pack house.

“Finn?” he asked as he walked close behind me. I shrugged.

“It is long overdue that I get a nickname for you,” I said.

“Works for me.” We entered the dining hall and saw that most of the pack had decided to eat breakfast together. As we walked up to our table both Meadow and Matilda gave me long hugs. We were all trying to get our lives back to a place that made sense. It was important to support and get support from your pack mates.

“Did you ask her?” Sam asked Finlay as we sat down.

“I did.” There was a pause in the conversation where everyone around the table but me looked at Finlay.

“And?” Sam asked.

“Did you think I would say no?” I asked him. He grinned at me and relaxed back in his chair. He put his arm around Medow and pulled her chair closer to him.

“No, you are smarter than that,” he said.

“What are you talking about?” Medow asked.

“I asked Amie to become the new Beta,” Finlay said.

“Oh. That’s good,” Medow said.

“The only option,” Matilda said and gave me a smile. I smiled back and nodded. We ate breakfast and when we were done, Finlay stood up and signed for me and Sam to join him.

“Yesterday was a tough day for the pack. We lost loved ones and others were hurt. But we also showed that we are a strong pack. We will not give up without a fight. We protect our pack and our land. Beta Martin gave his life in that pursuit. Today we will take revenge for him and for the others we lost. We can’t be without a Beta. It’s more important now than ever before to show that we remain strong. Our new Beta will be Amie, I don’t think I need to explain why. She will officially be sworn in as we lay Beta Martin to rest. But I know that you will all treat her as Beta from now on. If you have questions, or have concerns, you are always welcome to talk to anyone in the top tier. We are here for you. Thank you

everyone for your part yesterday. Everyone did what they should do and took the measures we have asked of you. It’s because of this we could win and only lose a few of our own. I am proud to be your Alpha,” Finlay told the pack. I got a lot of congratulations via mindlink and also pack members telling me they felt safe with me as Beta. It was overwhelming to feel everyone’s support. “In an hour the Alpha of the attacking pack will be executed outside the pack house. After that we will talk to the remaining members of his pack. You will decide their faith,” he then told them. After he was done, the pack scattered. Families with young pups wanted to get them away from what was about to happen, others wanted to stay to bear witness.

‘Ready?’ I asked Finlay in a mindlink.

‘Ready,’ he confirmed.

Chapter 24



Finlay

The area in front of the pack house had been cleared and the pack had gathered around the edges of it. Alpha Jackson stood in the middle of the area. He was guarded by Sam and a warrior. My wolf's hatred for the other Alpha was strong and I shared his feelings. Alpha Jackson was the reason I had lost my best friend. Whether it was by his own hands or not, his actions had caused my pack the loss of our Beta. If it wasn't for Amie, I don't know how I would have made it through the night. I was even more grateful for her stepping up as our new Beta. She walked beside me and I could feel her anger. We stopped in front of the defeated Alpha. I scanned the crowd, making sure no pups had sneaked out to see what was happening. When I knew the only ones around were pack members who should be there, I walked up to Alpha Jackson. Sam had him on his knees and I looked down on him.

"Bring out the representatives of the Rolling Hills pack," Amie called out. The pack members to the left of us made way for a group of warriors who guided an older man and woman to stand a bit away from where we stood. After what the

Alpha had revealed in our interrogation, we had let the Rolling Hills pack choose two representatives amongst the survivors.

"I, Alpha of the Blue Mountain pack, have talked to the council and presented the evidence of the Rolling Hills pack's attack on us. The council has decided the Alpha of the Rolling Hills pack has forfeited his life for his failure to protect and lead his pack to victory. As the winners, we may claim the blood debt for our fallen pack members," I told everyone with a clear voice. I let the information sink in. "The council left it up to us to decide what to do with the remainder of the Rolling Hills pack. We will deal with the issue next. But first, we will claim payment of our debt. For Beta Martin, Warrior Brian and Warrior Megan, we demand the blood of Alpha Jackson." I smiled down at the Alpha before me. I had no regrets about what I was about to do. I let my claws extend on my right hand and I used one of them to nick his artery. I did not want to give him a quick death. I took a step back, standing next to Amie. Everyone looked as Alpha Jackson slowly bleed out. As he swayed on his knees, the blood loss made it hard for him to remain kneeling. Sam and the warrior on the other side of the Alpha took a grip on his shoulders to keep him up. A while later I gave them a nod and they let the Alpha go. He fell forward into the leaves on the ground and his own blood. We all listened to the gurgling sounds as he took his last, desperate breath. Amie stepped forward and bent down over him to listen. She felt for a pulse.

"He's gone," she said. The pack raised their heads and howled. The victory was officially ours.

"Time for the next part," I said and everyone quieted down to listen. "Members of the Rolling Hills pack, your former Alpha admitted he planned and executed this attack against the will of your pack. That is the only reason you are still standing

here alive. Members of the Blue mountain pack, I will leave the decision of what we are to do with the remainder of the Rolling Hills pack up to you. Discuss it among yourself and this evening after dinner, we will have a pack meeting and decide their fates. Until then, bring the representatives back to their pack members," I told the pack before turning around and walking inside the pack house. Amie, Sam and Medow followed me and we gathered in the meeting room. I walked up to the chair Amie usually sat in and moved it to where it once had stood by the wall. Then I sat down in my seat. Sam and Medow also sat down. Amie remained standing, staring at the chair Martin usually sat in. "It's yours now," I told her.

"It feels disrespectful," she objected.

"He would have wanted you to sit there," Medow said and Sam nodded. Amie looked at me, I could see how uncomfortable she was and the sadness she tried to hide.

"It's okay," I said. She sighed, nodded and sat down on the edge of the chair. I resisted my urge to take her hand to comfort her. After our night mourning together, it felt as if the wall between us had weakened. I could feel it was harder to hold back the urge to be physically close to her. I rained in my emotions, now was not the time. "What is the state on the borders?" I asked.

"No further attacks seem to be imminent. The warriors report it's peaceful," Sam told me.

"How are the warriors holding up?" Amie asked.

"We have had one shift change so everyone on duty now has had a chance to rest and get food. We are all feeling the loss, but morale is high. The victory did them good," Sam said. We all nodded.

"What about funerals?" Medow asked.

"Tomorrow, after we settled things with the Rolling Hills pack. Then we will lay them to rest," Amie said. I grunted my approval. "I will talk with Megan's family. See if they have any special wishes," she added. Megan was the only one of the dead who had family in the pack. Brian had always said his family was the other warriors, and Martin, Martin was my family, and Amie's, and Sam and Medow's. We would give all of them a worthy send off.

"What do you think the pack will decide?" Medow asked us.

"I don't know," I honestly said. We weren't a violent pack, but everyone was upset over the attack and the people we had lost. Revenge could make the calmest wolf bloodthirsty.

"They won't demand blood," Amie said with confidence.

"Are you sure?" Sam asked. "The anger is palatable," he pointed out.

"I am. They will talk and at first they will be upset, but they will see the truth in the end. The remaining members of the Rolling Hills pack are no threat to us, and they were forced to be here. I don't doubt the pack will find a way to punish them. I just don't think it will involve taking their lives," she said. It was a typical Amie statement, she had absolute faith in our pack but not in a naïve way. No, she was a realist. She just spent so much time with the pack members she knew how the

pack as a whole worked. After watching her work with the pack for years, I wasn't surprised the moon goddess had placed her to be Luna of a pack. I would have her as my Luna in a heartbeat. I had met her former mate during the joint pack meetings. He seemed to be a reasonable Alpha. I had met her brother as well and I liked him, he reminded me of Amie. Each year I would ask Amie if she wanted me to bring a message to her brother. Each year she declined. But she kept sending her postcards. A knock on the door awoke me from my thoughts. Amie asked them to come in. My aunt stepped inside the room, pulling a trolley with lunch on.

"Since all of you seemed determined to starve yourself to death, despite someone needing the nutrition more than others," she said, giving Medow a look. Poor Sam paled. "I brought lunch to you."

"Thank you, aunt. How are things out there?" I asked. She walked around the table, putting down plates with food.

"As well as can be expected. It was a nice thing to let the pack decide the fate of the poor wolves left of the other pack," she told me and placed a kiss on my cheek before putting a big basket of bread and a pitcher with iced tea in the middle of the table.

"I'm happy you approve," I said.

"Thank you, Matilda. This looks amazing," Amie told her. My aunt placed a hand on Amie's back.

"I'm happy to do my part. Don't brood too long," she said and took the trolley with her as she left. We started eating and discussed what was next on our to-do list.

"I will handle the dishes," Medow said as we were done.

"I will help you," Amie offered.

"You have people to talk to," Medow said. Amie just shrugged and Medow nodded. We all needed to be around people we considered family.

"I will be right back, baby. I just need to check on the wounded warriors and then take a quick tour around the border to make sure things are as they should be," Sam told Medow.

"You can check on the injured warriors, I will run the border," I told him. He looked like he was about to object, then he looked at his mate and nodded.

"Don't worry, I'm not fragile and Amie will be with me," Medow told her mate and kissed his cheek. Sam and Amie exchanged a look and Amie nodded. I knew Amie and I both would make sure Sam and Medow could be together as much as possible. I admired Sam for not losing his marbles in the situation with Medow being pregnant. He was a strong wolf and we were lucky to have him as our Gamma.

'Be careful, look after your shoulder and mindlink me if something happens,' I linked Amie as I walked out of the pack house.

'There is nothing wrong with my shoulder. Take care out there,' she replied.



Amie

When Sam had come back and I was sure Medow was okay, I talked to Megan's father and sister. They didn't have any requests for the funeral. I stayed for a while and talked about Megan. They joined me on the walk back to the pack house. Most of the pack was heading there for dinner and then for the meeting. I watched as other pack members made sure Megan's family wasn't alone as I headed for the table where Finlay and Matilda already sat. They both looked tired. I knew Finlay hadn't slept for two days, I hadn't either. We had a couple of more hours of work before we could think about going to bed. Medow and Sam joined us and we ate our dinner in silence. The rest of the room was mostly silent as well. There was the sound of pups playing and a muted conversation here and there. But it was a vast difference from how a pack dinner usually sounded. When everyone was done and the dishes were put away, everyone looked towards Finlay. He stood up.

"We all know why we are here. Have you made a decision as a pack?" he asked. Jake stood up.

"Yes, Alpha, we have," he confirmed. Finlay nodded and asked them to tell him of their decision.



An hour later, we had all gathered in the new school gym. Finlay had arranged for video conference equipment to be set up and the screen switched on and showed a conference table with thirteen men and women sitting around it.

"Council, thank you for joining us," Finlay said.

"Alpha Finlay, under the circumstances we felt it necessary," said the man at the head of the table. Finlay nodded.

"I can confirm that Alpha Jackson has paid his debt," Finlay told the council and I could see them nod. "We are here to determine the punishment for the rest of the Rolling Hills pack. Bring the representatives forward," he continued. The same two wolves stepped forward from the group of prisoners.

"Alpha," they both said and bowed.

"The Blue Mountain pack has made the decision. As punishment for attacking our pack we won't claim a blood debt," Finlay told them and I could see the surprise in the representatives' eyes. They had counted on not leaving the building alive. "But there will be no rebuilding of the Rolling Hills pack, no new Alpha is to be chosen. The remaining members will be allowed to go home one last time to collect their belongings. But twenty-four hours later, they need to leave the old

pack land. From then they will be lone wolves. Families may stay together but otherwise they should not have contact with each other. If other packs are willing to accept them into their pack, we will not hold any resentment towards that pack. The pack land should be sold and the money should be handed over to the relief fund controlled by the council so it can help wolves in need," Finlay ended his sentencing. I smiled. The pack had found a way to erase the Rolling Hills pack from the map without bloodshed. I had never doubted them.

"That was an odd way of dealing with it," the head of the council said.

"But surprisingly likeable," another councilman said. His statement was met by humming and nodding from the other members.

"The council will uphold this sentence. We will send our warriors to escort the remaining prisoners to their former pack land and deal with the rest. Alpha Finlay, members of the Blue Mountain pack, you have done a good job and shown mercy. You are strong and I think this will deter other packs from doing the same," the head of the council said.

"We thank you," Finlay told him and did a half bow.

"Next game will be interesting. We might see some rearrangement at the top," a woman in the council said. I felt pride bloom inside me. We had a good pack. Finlay was concluding the call with the council.

"Beta Amie?" I almost didn't react to my new title. It would take getting used to.

"Yes, Cade," I said, turning towards Cadence.

"How is your shoulder?" he half whispered. I smiled at him.

"It's much better, almost healed. Thank you for asking. How are you feeling?" I asked him.

"Oh, I'm fine. My mom fusses over me and even Mari is nice to me. It's a bit weird," he told me. I chuckled and messed his hair up. As Finlay was done and turned off the equipment, I told Cadence I had to go. I was walking towards Finlay, Sam and Medow.

"Beta? Excuse me, Beta?" I turned around at the unknown voice and saw the older woman from the Rolling Hills pack trying to get my attention. Two of our warriors made sure she couldn't go past the area we had dedicated to the prisoners. I walked up to her, but kept my distance. I nodded to the warriors and they stood to the side.

"Yes?" I asked.

"Regarding the sentence. Can you ask the Alpha to change it? We know the pack land we have isn't much. But it kept the pack alive until our latest Alpha started spending money as if we could grow them. We can't lose the land our pack has lived on for generations," she begged me. I looked at her, she must have called me over because she thought it would be easier to sell me a sob story.

"No. I know your Alpha didn't listen to you, but in this pack, when the pack speaks, the Alpha listens. And it's not your pack land anymore, you don't have a pack. You lost that privilege when you attacked my pack. We may be peaceful and we don't like to be cruel. But we aren't weak. You tried to take us over. For that, your pack will be erased from the surface of this world," I told her.

"Please, show mercy. We didn't want to attack your pack. We had no choice," she said.

"You had a choice. You could have warned us, you could have told the council that your Alpha was forcing you. There were several things you could have done."

"It would have been to betray the pack," she objected.

"No. It would have been to honour your pack, but betray your Alpha. You made your choice. Now you have to live with the consequences of that decision. I feel my pack has been more than generous in how they decided to handle you. Be happy you are walking out of here and can reunite with your families. Not many packs will be willing to take you in, but at least you have a chance to find a new pack. Be grateful." I turned my back on her and walked away.

"Are you okay, Red?" Finlay mindlinked me as I joined him, Sam and Meadow.

"Fine. If one of the prisoners happens to die during the night, would that be bad?" I answered. He grinned and shook his head.

"I think it's time we all head to bed," he said out loud. "Some of us are starting to get grumpy." Meadow nodded and yawned.

"I will carry you," Sam offered his mate.

"I can walk," she objected. He sighed, but nodded. The pack was splitting up as well, everyone heading for their home except the ones who would relieve the warriors on duty. I waved as Meadow and Sam turned from us to head to their house.

"Will you be okay?" Finlay asked again as we paused outside the pack house. I was going inside and he was heading to his house.

"I will be. I'm tired enough to fall asleep the second I hit the bed. How about you?"

"I will be happy if I can hold out until I get upstairs to the bedroom. It's a fifty-fifty chance I won't make it past the couch," he told me.

"Suck it up, Alpha. You need a good night's sleep. Sleep in your bed," I told him.

"Aye, aye, Beta Amie," he joked. I shook my head as we parted. I wanted to follow him back to his place. What I would do if I did, I didn't know. I forced my feet to take me into the pack house. It was the safer option.



Three pyres were built in the glade where we usually celebrated the full moon. A body laid on top of each pyre. As the day turned to dusk, Megan's father and sister stepped forward and shared memories of her. Then some of the warriors talked about Brian. Then Finlay stepped up.

"Martin and I met as pups. We grew up together, we learned about life together and how to be wolves together. He was my brother. He never hesitated to follow me when I broke off from our old pack. He loved this pack, and he was proud of what we have become. Martin made the biggest sacrifice anyone can make. He

gave his life for this pack and we honour him for it." Finlay stepped back and I took a step forward.

"When I arrived at this pack, Martin was one of the more enthusiastic to get to know me. He knew I grew up in a Beta family and he wanted me to teach him to be a good Beta. I never needed to teach him anything. He was a natural. Instead of becoming his teacher, I became his friend. In Martin I found a friend, a confidant, and an older brother. As I shoulder the mantel he left behind, he will be my inspiration and my role model. He was our first Beta and we will remember him as a Beta all other Betas will look up to." I stepped back to stand between Finlay and Sam. Medow, Matilda and Megan's sister stepped forward. They all had a lit torch in their hands. Each of them lit a pyre and then stepped back. We watched as the fire took hold and soon all three pyres were in full flame. After a while, the pack walked around, talking to each other, eating from the food that was laid out, and sitting down to talk amongst themselves. I walked over to Matilda and gave her a hug.

"How are you holding up? You are always looking after us, but don't think I don't know you have spent most of your waking hours in the kitchen, making sure the pack is fed," I told her.

"I'm okay. They were all good wolves and I hate to see them go this early. But I like to keep busy," she said. "Thank you for looking after my nephew. This has been hard on him. The two of them were inseparable since they were pups. I know he doesn't like to let it show, but he is devastated," she added, and we both looked in Finlay's direction. He looked up at me as if he felt me looking and raised an eyebrow. I smiled at him and turned back to Matilda.

"To be honest, he is helping me as much as I'm helping him. I feel like I have lost my brother." Matilda smiled a sad smile, and we hugged again.

"It will get better. It's never easy to lose the ones we love. But we learn to live with it and find our way to a new way to live." She walked away to make sure Medow and Shelly had things to eat. Finlay walked up to me.

"Were the two of you talking about me?" he asked.

"Now, now, Alpha. Don't let that ego get the best of you. There are other subjects than you," I teased him. He smiled.

"Will you join me as I make the rounds?" he asked.

"Sure," I agreed and we walked around the pyres, talking with the pack and listening to memories they wanted to share, fears they had and how they now, more than ever, felt like this pack was the right choice for them.



I stood in the door opening and looked into the Beta office. It was the day after the funeral and Finlay had ordered me to move into my new office. It was a direct order, there was no way to interpret it differently. I got it. If he had let me do it at my own pace, I would probably have taken years to move my things from my office, the former storage room, into my official one. I sighed and looked over the room.

‘Have you started?’ Finlay mindlinked me.

‘Yes,’ I answered.

‘Have you actually stepped inside the room?’ Sometimes I hated how well he knew me. I place one foot inside the room.

‘I have,’ I told him.

‘Just do it, Amie. Everyone will feel better when things settle down. The more things we leave in the air, the harder it will be.’ I knew he was right.

‘I know. I’m on my way.’ I took a proper step inside the room, and as I did, something started to ring. I froze in place and felt like a burglar that had been caught red-handed. Until I realized it was the landline phone. All the top tier offices had one. I shook my head at myself and walked over to the desk.

“Amie Sage,” I answered the phone.

“Hello, my name is Bridget. Am I talking to the Beta of the Blue mountain pack?” a woman said on the other end. I knew the name.

“Hi, it is. Are you Martin’s sister?” I asked.

“I am. I’m sorry to call like this, I didn’t know if Alpha Finlay would have time for my call and I really don’t have the phone number for anyone else,” she explained.

“No, no. I don’t mind and neither would Finn... the Alpha,” I told her. “What can I do for you?”

“I...” there was a pause and then a sigh. “The family couldn’t attend the funeral for my brother. It wasn’t the right time,” she started over. I could read between the lines, either her mate or the Alpha had denied her to come. “I would like to ask if it would be possible to send some of my brother’s personal effects to me or my mother?” she asked.

“Of course, we would be more than happy to do so. We will clear out his house tomorrow. Martin had a will and he specified which things should be sent back to you. I will make sure you get them,” I promised.

“Oh, thank you. I can’t believe he is really gone. I always thought we would have time to put things right between him and dad. That I would get to see him again. And now he is gone.” I could clearly hear the grief in her voice.

“He talked a lot about you. He missed you.” I didn’t know if I was making it better or worse.

“Thank you. We would call each other at least once a month to talk. He talked a lot about you as well. He liked you and saw you as a close friend,” she told me. I smiled with tears in my eyes.

“He was an amazing wolf,” I said.

“He was,” she agreed. “I need to go, my mate will be home from training soon and I like to have dinner ready when he does. It gives us more time to hang out in the evening. It was nice talking to you and thank you for giving me your time.”

"It was my pleasure. I'll make sure the things will be sent to you. If there is anything else you need, give me a call. Or Alpha Finlay." As we hung up, I felt better than I had done before the call. I started looking over the things in the office, sorting Martin's personal things from the things that were Beta related. Two hours later, Finlay leaned against the door frame and looked at me.

"How is it going?" he asked.

"I'm almost done. I have packed Martin's things in that box and I have packed my things in my office. I'm just doing a bit of dusting before I go and get my things," I told him.

"Feeling better about the move?"

"Yes. I spoke to Martin's sister. She wanted to know if we could send some of his things to her. I said I promised to make it happen." He nodded. "Thank you for pushing me. I needed it," I added. He gave me a weak smile.

"We all need it right now."

"Have you heard from the council?" I asked.

"The Rolling Hills pack land is now empty of wolves and the pack is officially disbanded," he told me. It was my turn to nod. "It's time for lunch, I will help you carry Martin's things to his house after we eat and get your things. But my aunt will be worried if we skip another meal," he told me.

"You know I can carry the boxes myself," I said as I walked up to him.

"I know, Red. But I will do it." Stubborn Alpha. I didn't object, I would find a way to pay him back.



Chapter 26



Amie

‘Amie!’ The mindlink from Medow woke me up.

‘Medow?’ I asked.

‘It’s time,’ she told me. I was wide awake at once.

‘On my way,’ I linked her as I was putting on my pants and trying to pull a t-shirt over my head at the same time.

‘Please hurry.’ The last link had me worried something was wrong. We had been preparing for weeks for Medow’s and Sam’s daughter to be born. Her parents had arrived two weeks earlier and they were lovely wolves. Her mother and I had got along amazingly as we helped Medow get ready. I sprinted out of the pack house and headed for their home. Finlay joined me and we both grinned at each other.

“Shelly has also gone into labour,” he informed me.

“Two pups the same night? Did you put something in the food?” I teased him. He laughed.

“I will head over to Jake and Shelly first. Let Medow and Sam know I will be there to keep her dad company as soon as I can,” he said. I nodded as we split up. I arrived at the house, knocked on the door and walked inside. Medow’s dad was walking back and forth in the living room.

“The Alpha will be here soon, we have another pack member giving birth as well,” I told him. He smiled at me and nodded. I headed up the stairs and headed for the bedroom. I knocked on the door and heard a loud growl. Oboy, Sam was in a good mood.

‘That better be you, Amie,’ Medow mindlinked me. I stepped into the room.

“Oh thank goddess!” she exclaimed when she saw me. She was sitting on the edge of the bed, leaning against her mother that held a cloth to her neck. Next to them, Sam stood and looked from me to the two healers that stood in a corner.

“For the sake of the moon, Sam. Get a grip. We are all here to help Medow,” I huffed as I closed the door behind me.

“She is in pain,” he said. I could hear the equal parts of fear, panic and anger in his voice.

“I know. But she won’t be in any less pain because you act like a cave wolf.” I told him. I walked up to Medow and kissed her head. “You are doing amazing, I’m proud of you. Don’t worry about the idiotic mate you have. I got him,” I told her. She relaxed and let out a giggle.

"I knew it was a good idea to have you here," she told me. I smiled and walked up to Sam and put my hand on his shoulder.

"You should focus on supporting your mate. I will make sure no one does something stupid. The only thing that matters is Medow and the pup. That is your job. I will take care of everything else. Finlay will make sure everything is okay downstairs when he arrives. He just needed to look in on Jake and Shelly. You are not the only one who is getting ready to have a pup today."

"Oh, that's exciting," Medow said.

"The pack is doing good," her mother remarked. I smiled and agreed.

Just before dawn, Finlay sent out a pack mindlink to let everyone know Jake and Shelly had a daughter, the pack had a new member. They named her Rose. Three hours later, Medow gave birth to a girl. She was perfect and had a generous amount of almost white blond hair on her head.

"You did good," I told Medow as she rested in bed with the little one in her arms, Sam was sitting next to her, with his arms around her. He was mesmerised by his daughter. Medow's mother was thanking the healers. There was a light knock on the door and Finlay stepped into the room.

"Congratulations," he told our friends with a huge smile.

"Thank you, Alpha," they both said. I made a place for him by the bed so he could bend over and have a look at the pup.

"She is perfect," he told the proud parents. "Have you decided on a name?" Medow looked up at her mate with a smile.

"Martina," he told Finlay. I felt a pang in my heart and both Finlay and I smiled.

"A good name," Finlay told them and then he sent out the second pack link of the day to announce a new pack member had been born. I gave Medow a gentle hug and kissed Sam on the cheek before I left them in the capable hands of Medow's mother. Finlay and I walked downstairs and I talked a little with Medow's father before he headed upstairs to see his grandchild and Finlay and I headed towards the pack house.

"Aunt Matilda is orchestrating a feast both for lunch and dinner," Finlay told me.

"That sounds right," I said and tried to hide a yawn.

"Take the morning off and take a nap," he suggested.

"I'm fine. I just need some coffee and I'm good to go. You have been awake just as long as I have and I don't see you napping," I told him.

"I just sat around waiting, you actually did things."

"I can't argue with that. Sam certainly had it out for the poor healers at one point." Finlay laughed.

"The pack is grateful you saved two of our healers' lives. They are useful to have around." I laughed as well.

“How about breakfast?” I asked.

“How about we wait thirty minutes and grab lunch instead?” he countered.

“Is it really that late?”

“It is.” He looked at me. “Maybe you should get some food and head off to bed.”

“It’s not that bad. I will be fine.”

“Amie!” We both turned around to see Cadence and his sister walking towards us.

“Hi Cade, Mari. I hear congratulations are in order. How is your mom?” I asked.

“She and the pup are both well, thank you. They are resting and dad is keeping an eye on them. He sent us to have lunch in the pack house,” Mari told us.

“How do you feel about being a big brother, Cade?” I asked.

“It’s okay. She is really small so there is not much for me to do right now,” he told me.

“Sounds about right. My brother told me I was really boring the first year of my life. You just need to hang in there, it will get better,” I said.

“Yeah. You were boring as well,” Mari told her little brother. Cadence didn’t look happy about that. Finlay and I exchanged an amused look. We joined the two of them for lunch and the other pack members came by to say congratulations to the two siblings.

“I’ll get the casseroles I know Matilda has ready and hand them to the two families,” I told Finlay after we had eaten.

“I can send some one if you need a nap,” he offered.

“No need. I will take a nap once I’m done,” I promised. He reluctantly nodded and I headed for the kitchen. As I had expected, Matilda had a big food package for each of the families and I headed off with Mari and Cadence. We stopped at Medow and Sam’s place. Her father took the food and thanked me. I didn’t want to disturb the new parents so we headed for Mari and Cadence’s house next. Cadence walked right inside.

“Mom, dad, we’re home and we brought Beta Amie!” he called at the top of his lungs. Mari sighed and shook her head.

“Cadence, you need to keep your voice down. Rose and your mother are trying to sleep,” his father told him.

“Sorry,” Cadence whispered and looked like a sad puppy. His father ruffled his hair.

“Welcome, Beta,” he then said.

“Thank you. I’m just here to hand over some food. I think it’s enough here for at least five days. If you need more or any other help, please let us know,” I told him and handed him the basket of food.

“Thank you. It is greatly appreciated. You would think it would be easier when it’s your third, but it’s still just as world shattering,” he said with a smile. It let me

know he didn't mind the process at all. He paused for a moment. "Shelly asked if you have a moment to come and see her and the pup?" he asked.

"Of course. I'm not disturbing her and the pup?" I asked.

"No, no. If she asked for you, it's okay," he said. "Cadence, show the Beta to your mother and I will put away the food," he added. Cadence nodded.

"I will help you dad," Mari said as Cadence and I headed further into the house. The house was a one story home and the bedroom was at the back of the house. I gently knocked on the bedroom door and then Cadence and I stepped inside.

"Beta, thank you for seeing me," Shelly said from the bed. She spoke in a hushed voice. The little newborn pup was in a bassinet next to the bed.

"Not at all, how are you feeling?" I asked in the same hushed tone.

"I'm fine, just a little tired. I wanted to make sure you didn't take offence that we named the little one after you," Shelly said. I smiled at her.

"Not at all, it is an honour." She returned my smile. She reached out and brushed her hand over Cadence's hair. He was standing and looking into the bassinet at his little sister.

"After what you did for our boy, it felt like the right thing to do," she said. I joined Cadence and looked down on the sleeping pup.

"She is beautiful. Just perfect," I told her mother. Shelly beamed.

"She is. How is Medow?" she asked.

"Doing good. We stopped by on our way here and she and Martina were sleeping," I told her.

"I remember being a first time mom. It takes some getting used to. I hope the two of us can lean on each other," Shelly said.

"I think she will like that," I agreed. I said goodbye and walked back to the front of the house.

"Beta," Jake said.

"Yes?"

"I hope this doesn't take me out of the running for the games. I know it sounds bad. But they are still four months away and I think Shelly will be able to manage for a month without me. She has Mari and Cadence to help," he told me. I smiled at him. He had been so reluctant at first to even consider participating. But the last couple of years, he had put his all into training.

"It doesn't. We will choose the participants in about three months and talk to the ones we chose before we make it public. If everything is okay then, we are good," I told him. He relaxed. As I made my way back to the pack house, I tried not to yawn. I really needed a nap. Jake's question had the nerves in my stomach come to life. They always did when thinking about the games. One part was the games themselves. They were important for the pack's future. But if, or rather when, I went, there was no getting away from running into James and my brother. No

more hiding in the shadows. It would also be the best chance for Finlay to find his mate. The closer the games got, the worse my nerves felt.



Chapter 27



Amie

I was in my office and looked at the short list of potential members to take to the games. We could bring five and we needed a rounded team, ready to take on everything. There was a knock on the doorframe, my door usually was open when I was in my office. I looked up and saw Meadow and Martina. I smiled at them.

"Hello, if it isn't the cutest wolf in the pack," I said.

"Hi, it is, and she has her daughter with her as well," Meadow said and we both laughed. "What is the birthday girl doing all hidden away?" Meadow asked. "The rest of the pack is preparing your celebration."

"I know. I just have a couple of more things to do," I told her. For years, my birthday had been my least favourite day. It held memories I would rather forget. When I lived in the human world, I had done my best to avoid it. But since coming to the pack, I had started to celebrate it again. It was hard to avoid, as both Meadow and Matilda insisted, and Finlay had refused to help me tell them no. I had become better each year. But this year was tricky. We were a month away

from the games and my nerves were on edge. Meadow walked up to me and held Martina on one arm as she put a hand on my shoulder.

"Do you want to talk about it?" she asked.

"No. I'm fine," I told her. She raised an eyebrow and I had to giggle at how good she had become at the 'mom-look'.

"Do I need to tell Finlay?" she asked.

"Okay, I'm mostly fine," I corrected myself. "It's just a lot at the moment with the games, and trying to prepare for meeting James and my brother again," I confessed. Meadow sat down in my visitor's chair.

"I can understand that. Is it just bad nerves?" she asked.

"No. Part of me is looking forward to the games. I think we have a good chance at doing really well. And I'm looking forward to meeting Elder. I just hope he isn't too angry with me."

"It will be fine," Meadow said. "I'm a mother, I know these things," she added. I laughed.

"Thank you for cheering me up," I said.

"You are welcome. You can pay me back by babysitting Martina next Saturday so me and my mate can have some alone time. I think the little monster has a built-in sensor for when we are starting to get things going."

"Hey there! No need to tell me things. I would love to babysit. Just drop her off and the two of us will have a girls day," I agreed.

"Thank you. Now I think you could use a walk and then you need to get ready. I'm not letting you miss your own birthday party. I'm sending Finlay to get you at six. At least I know he won't let you stay at home."

"Fine, fine. I will yield," I said and put my things away, shut down my laptop and closed my office. "I'm taking a stroll by the creek, if you need me just mindlink," I told her and caressed Martina over her head. I took the path Martin and I always used. I plopped down in our spot and let myself feel how much I missed him. I relaxed and listened to the water and enjoyed the summer sun. It did wonders and half an hour later I was ready to head back to the pack house to get ready. Meadow, Shelly and I had taken a shopping trip a couple of weeks ago. The two of them felt they needed new clothes after the pregnancy, and I joined them. I found a forest green summer dress I fell in love with. It was just what I needed for the party. After a shower I put the dress on and for once I pinned my hair up. I was happy with the result as there was a nock on the door. I looked at my phone, six o'clock on the dot. I smiled as I opened the door.

"Hello, Alpha," I said. Finlay smiled back at me.

"Happy birthday Amie, you look beautiful tonight," he told me and held out a tiger lily.

"Thank you," I said and took the flower. "One moment," I said and walked into my room to find something to put the flower in. I placed it on the table by the window and could feel Finlay's eyes on me as I moved around. When I turned back to him, he was leaning against my door frame, looking sexier than anyone

had the right to. I hoped he couldn't hear how my heart skipped a beat and then set off at a rapid pace.

"And a birthday gift," he said. From nowhere he pulled out a small box.

"Finlay, we don't give each other gifts," I objected. Everyone in our friend group had agreed on it. The only ones we gave gifts to were the children, well, the child.

"Uhu, that is why you got me my favourite pen on my birthday?" he asked.

"That was just something I happened to run into around your birthday," I told him.

"Just open the gift, Red," he told me. I walked over to him and took the little box.

"Thank you," I said.

"Traditionally, you thank someone when you have seen what the gift is," he pointed out. I smiled and untied the ribbon and opened the lid. Inside was a thin gold chain with a gold pendant. The pendant was round and flat. Engraved on it was a howling wolf with a mountain as a backdrop. Instead of a moon, there was a red stone set in the pendant.

"Finn, it's beautiful. Thank you!" I told him and let my finger caress the pendant.

"I'm happy you like it. It's your birthstone," he told me.

"I love it. Will you help put it on?"

“Sure,” he said and stood up. I took the necklace out of the box and handed it to him. He placed it around my neck and fastened it. I put my hand over the pendant. “Ready to have some fun?” he asked.

“I am.” Together we walked downstairs and out. Thanks to the amazing weather, the party was to be held in the glade where we had most official parties and gatherings. I could hear the music and see the bonfire long before we arrived. As we arrived, Matilda saw us.

“The birthday girl is here!” she called out, and everybody cheered. Matilda, Meadow and Shelly all came to hug me. Cadence ran up to me and gave me a wooden wolf he had made himself. It was a little crooked and lopsided, but it was cute and still looked like a wolf.

“How much food have you cooked?” I asked Matilda. She laughed at my comment.

“I’m anticipating we will be here all night, we will need food,” she told me. I had let my friends make my birthday party bigger than usual. Everyone was tense about the upcoming games. They needed to have some fun and my birthday was just the distraction they needed. I talked to Sam while we filled our plates. As we stood eating and talking, pack members drifted by to congratulate me and praise Meadow and Matilda for the incredible party. Once everyone had taken their first round of food, Matilda tapped a lid, and the crowd instantly fell silent.

“Time for cake,” she announced. Everyone cheered again. Three of the kitchen staff came carrying an enormous cake. It made sense as it needed to be enough for the entire pack. But it was a throwback to my eighteenth birthday, and I fought against the memories. The cake was decorated as a large, blue mountain with trees

and wolves spread all over it. It was an amazing cake. I focused on the differences to stay in the moment. The pack gathered around the cake as Matilda lit all the candles. They all sang Happy Birthday and I did my best to blow out all twenty-eight candles in one go. There was another cheer as I succeeded and next thing the cake was being cut into portions. I got the first piece and I discovered it was red velvet cake with fresh raspberries and blueberries in the filling.

“Matilda, you are amazing. This is the best cake I have ever had,” I told her after the first taste. She smiled and blushed. The party continued. People talked, laughed, danced and some shifted to run in the woods. The food was amazing and I lost count on how many pieces of cake I had eaten. I had danced with Finlay, Sam and Jake and turned down three other men. It was well after midnight and I stepped away from the bonfire as I needed to cool down.

“Tired?” Finlay asked as he walked up to me.

“Mostly hot,” I said. “But I’m starting to reach my limit for partying. I’m getting old,” I said and laughed.

“Watch your tongue,” he said in a huff and then chuckled. I laughed even more as I knew he was two years older than me. “How about we steal a piece of cake each and head over to my place. We can sit on the porch and watch the creek while we eat it. It should cool you down before bed,” he suggested. It was too good of an offer to turn down. I did a little round to say good night to my friends while Finlay stole some cake. We met up at the path back to the pack house and he handed me a plate with a big piece of cake.

“I will have dreams about this cake,” I happily told him as we walked back. He just chuckled at me. Finlay and I sat down on the step leading from his porch to